“WHEREVER COMMUNISTS CAN FUNCTION PROPERLY WITHIN A DEMOCRATIC SYSTEM, THEY WILL…”

Jyoti Basu was a communist politician from Bengal who served as chief minister of the state from 1977 to 2000 and co-founded the Communist Party of India (Marxist). In 1977, the CPI(M) led the coalition of parties that formed the government in West Bengal. Under Basu’s leadership, the government enacted land reforms that redistributed wealthy landowners’ land to poor farmers, and created a strong village panchayat system to put power in the hands of the state’s rural poor. However, the three decades of communist rule in Bengal also saw economic stagnation and a high degree of corruption. Nonetheless, Basu is credited with helping to bring some stability to a state that had suffered a terrible famine in 1943–44 and violent communal riots during Partition.

KANSHI RAM

1934–2006



“I AM A RUSTIC MAN, AND LIKE A RUSTIC PERSON CHURNS CURD TO PRODUCE BUTTER, I, TOO, AM CHURNING SOCIETY.”